of any adversary and thus guarantee our territorial integrity. Modernization and upgradation of the weapons and equipment systems and intelligence and surveillance capabilities, and an effective command and control set-up is the mantra for our armed forces. As has been our experience, capability building takes time, whereas intentions can change rapidly. It would be axiomatic to point out that this calls for a well-led, -trained and -equipped military with an updated and compatible joint doctrine to face the challenges of the battlefield of tomorrow, which will be digitized and netcentric.

This joint doctrine was approved by the chiefs of staff committee in 2007 and is being implemented. As a mature and responsible emerging power we cannot afford to be below par as far as capabilities are concerned. However, we have learnt our lessons from history, both ancient and recent, and have realized that a 'unilateral desire for peace cannot by itself guarantee a secure environment'. We need an iron fist and a velvet glove. We have to be strong to deter aggression, and we cannot be an economic giant without the ability to defend ourselves and safeguard our core values as a nation.

I started my innings as the chief of army staff with a clear aim that comprised operational readiness, high state of training, modernizing the army to cover enhanced night-fighting capability, use of information technology in warfare, success in counterterrorism operations, joint warfare, force restructuring and welfare of soldiers. It gives me immense satisfaction to note that we have achieved reasonable progress in these areas. Today, the army is much better prepared for any contingency as compared to the past. The doctrine for the army has been introduced and validated successfully. This has been complemented by realistic and well-phased training schedules, which focused on keeping the army 'ready and relevant', and at the same time gave the much desired rest to troops in peace stations.